

THIS BOY THAT I'VE FOUND

A New Type of Love

By Tyler Wade

Dedicated to the people whose love made me grow, learn, and live.

Forever grateful for the motivation of my mother to finish this.

A special thanks to the baristas for the space and fuel.

CAST

SPIROS - Male. Early 20's. Upset with his stance in life. Sulkish and cynical.

NICO - Male. Early 20's. Spiros' literal other half that only he can see. The two boys look almost strikingly similar.

GABRIEL - Male. Mid 20's. White. Spiros' first love. Lanky and lame.

DORIAN - Male. Early 20's. Short. Athletic. Fine kept hair, teeth, and nails. Metrosexual to the max.

RAINER - Male. Early 20's. Latino. Another rebound. Kind, cute, charming.

BARRY - Male. Mid 20's. Spiros' best friend. Looks very similar to Spiros. Depressed.

LORELEI - Neutral. Early 20's. Beautiful and prefers androgynous clothing.

Disillusioned by life, but strong willed. Tori's partner in life first, lover second.

TORI - Female. Early 20's. Kind and youthful. Extremely energetic and charismatic.

Lorelei's lover first, partner second.

FLORENCE - Female. Early 20's. Spunky. Rebellious. Stunning and astounding.

AMANDA - Female. Early 40's. Spiros' cool aunt. She is the only family member that tries to understand his plight.

GRAM

PAPAW

Ensembles

The Family - includes Spiros' family. Amanda, Gram, Papaw.

The Gaggle - includes Barry, Lorelei, Tori

The Men - includes Gabriel, Rainer, Gabriel

Notes

In this play, Nico is a projection of Spiros' ego. He is the version of Spiros who is better looking, disciplined, easier to love, and able to love more in return. The two boys often fight over Spiros' choices, inaction, and sins.

Amanda is played by the actor portraying Florence. They may be done up to look older.

PROLOGUE I THINK HE'S GOOD FOR ME

A garden at night. The space is covered in faux grass that looks real from afar. Rocks and logs for a fire litter the ground. Two boys sit barefoot in white tank tops with khakis. Spiros and Nico. They look strikingly similar. They're surrounded by paintings of naked boys and papers from a manuscript. Spiros holds the papers up to the light and tries to make out something more in them. Nico runs his hands over the paintings, sometimes getting extremely close to them hoping to catch more detail.

SPIROS

(slowly)

I haven't been inspired since I was a kid. Nothing's original. Everyone's so strict these days and absolute. It leaves me with heartache for society. It leaves me with empty stories. Empty souls. Empty beds. Empty bottles. If others can be so definitive, why can't I?

The two boys hold up various pieces of art and paper.

NICO

(bluntly)

All of these are stolen.

SPIROS

I enjoy them. I digest them, indulge in them, and splurge on my soul. I revel and relish in the feelings they emote hoping my own stories might evoke the same. I write at the beginning of things in anticipation of them ending. I sit facing doors when I'm alone and can't decide which chair to choose because of the laws of feng shui. I make eggs and bagels because he did. I scrub with a luffa and wring it in the same pattern. My taste in coffee and cream is the same as his. I make the lunch he loved. I listen to our music and cry at the worst moments.

NICO

I dream with both eyes open.

SPIROS

I dream with both eyes open.

SPIROS

I dream he might have been different and that I become someone else. I dream that all these good things come to a standstill until the end.

NICO

At some point, all these good things do end.

SPIROS

That's how I know they were good. They're over. I miss them. These moments whisper sweetly to me when the world reeks of neglect. The moments of years passed propagate alternative timelines in my silly head, and I desire.

NICO

Desires of the past are omnipresent and potent. They have power over dreams and passions. They rule people.

SPIROS

(turns to Nico)

People like me. Maybe people like you, that is if you've loved someone once. I don't know if you love as I do. Like I have, but—

The boys take a moment. They study each other and then all at once/

NICO

You look like me.

SPIROS

You look like me.

NICO

You sound like me, or how I used to sound.

SPIROS

You sit like me.

NICO

You smell like me.

They touch each other's cheeks. Nico travels his fingers across Spiros' lips.

SPIROS

You feel like me.

Spiros brings his hand down Nico's chest, then to his heart.

NICO

You touch like me.

SPIROS

Do you love as I do?

NICO

I have loved a thousand times.

SPIROS

Do you believe in the God I plead to?

NICO

My God's forsaken me.

SPIROS

Do you pursue sex in spite of its dangers?

NICO

No, sex pursues me.

SPIROS

Do you purge emotions as you gather more from strangers
that you'd rather never have met at all?

NICO

My strangers build me into something better. My emotions
fuel this fire.

SPIROS

Do you desire as dastardly and desperately as I do?

NICO

Desires are deadly. They're murders of romantics and
artists alike. Desire spills blood like nobody's business.

SPIROS

I'm a masochist.

NICO

You'd be better off as a mother if you're a masochist. Your
deaths don't have to be in vain. Bring up a child. Give this
world something worth offering through your pain.

SPIROS

I would, but I die every time before he comes to term, and now I tire. I've died for my thousandth time.

(to God)

God, does this pain linger? Will you deliver me from it?

(grasps Nico)

Will you suture stagnant memories and sullied sorries? Do you wish me sorrow? Is *he* why this pain persists? Because another out there like me exists and is better.

(to God)

Do you care for me? Are you still there? Were you ever there at all?

NICO

Your faith is founded on what?

SPIROS

Blessings and depression. Unfulfillment and disastrous acts. The few good moments that I'm gifted.

NICO

There are other moments out there. They torment. They bring about night terrors. Chaotic. Volatile.

SPIROS

Invisibly violent in nature. Splicing and splitting my essence and our likeness.

NICO

Moments filled with strangers handing out tempered touches. Faux fucks. Kleptic Kisses. With every kiss, they steal a piece of you. Chip away at your soul. These are not the good times. He holds a pillow over your face every night and you wonder why you wake so often. He crushes your ribcage in your sleep then paints over your bruises with himself in the morning. He slackens your jaw, softens your touch, and spreads your hips when he parts your lips. He famishes you and convinces you that you must sustain yourself on his grace. You are made a servant of his in return for his so called love that will never last and that you will never find again. All of these things have made you vulnerable to others. They seek to take advantage of perturbed pups, and they are here tonight.

SPIROS

I don't know these moments, not yet, but I recognize the chaos. There's a whole generation of boys out there who want to grow old with someone who looks and feels like them. Why? Why are so many of them comfortable tossing the possibility of a life with a woman out the window?

NICO

Because too many fathers have forgotten.

SPIROS

Lost us.

NICO

Failed us.

SPIROS

Disregarded us with disgust and disdain.

NICO

How many of us disregard our own lives and deny ourselves some semblance of normalcy?

SPIROS

And why do I do the same?

NICO

And why do I do the same?

SPIROS

If you never love me again, then why should anyone find solace in these hips? That's the nature of this world. And when there are so many hips out there to soil, mine are lost in the sea. So I keep these hips to myself in hopes they'll hold up a child one day.

NICO

If someone doesn't want my company, then nobody wants my company. That's the law of this life.

SPIROS

Nico, I don't think my family will ever understand the shame I carry, let alone the desire I have to fill a baby boy with all my wants and love. I can't reconcile these two truths. I can't understand why I deny myself a normal life. I deny myself the moment of my wife saying/

FLORENCE (O.S.)

Spiros, you're going to be a father.

ALL

I love you and I can't wait.

SPIROS

I'm going to build a fire.

NICO

What for?

SPIROS

To keep him warm.

NICO

Who?

SPIROS

My baby.

NICO

But you haven't got one.

SPIROS

I will. I'm going to be a father and he's got to stay warm.

Spiros picks up the rocks and logs. He arranges them in a fire.

NICO

Are you disgusted with yourself? Is this why you've created this fantasy you're inseparable from? Would you rather hide away in a psychosis?

SPIROS

... Yes. Usually. It depends on the day. On the days I give in to it.

NICO

Desire?

SPIROS

Sure, among other things.

NICO

You feel shame.

SPIROS

The family will never understand. Not like you do.

NICO

I've lived with it as long as you have. I know about it all too well.

SPIROS

Should I tell them this year?

NICO

You don't have anyone to offer them. No baby. No boy. No sanity. You'll destroy the dynasty without proper reparations.

SPIROS

So I've got to enter hell by myself.

NICO

You've got me.

SPIROS

I've got you and all your wondrous ideas about who I could be.

NICO

Who you're meant to be. What you're meant to do. What you're going to become. You can't worry about what you don't have to offer, and you don't need a baby to define you. You are bright by yourself. You'll be a flame to them one day, just not today.

Spiros lights a match and tosses it into the logs.

SPIROS

It's been dark here for so long Nico. Do you understand that?

NICO

I do.

SPIROS

I'll show them how I love. How I lust. How I trust. How I
desire. I'll be a flame today, and God will it be good.

The fire roars to life.

SPIROS (CONT'D)

It must be.

SCENE I BOYS AND BABIES

A Thanksgiving dinner. The table stretches from end to end of the stage. Candles and glasses without wine fill the table. Spiros and Nico dawn sweaters. A dual sided full body mirror appears. The boys fix themselves up while looking at opposite sides of the mirror. They sit next to each other in the middle of the table.

NICO

You know this is hell.

SPIROS

I hate coming back here.

NICO

But we always do.

SPIROS

I need to. It's the right thing to do.

NICO

Gotta have a family.

SPIROS

Can't do life without a family.

NICO

It doesn't have to be this one.

SPIROS

Yes, because my attempts to make a family with boys have panned out so well.

NICO

I think you need to try harder. You need to go to the gym.

SPIROS

Me. What about you?

NICO

(flexes in his sweater)

I watch what I eat, even when you don't.

SPIROS

I don't like listening to you at these types of things. You always say the worst you can think of.

NICO

These *family functions* keep us in check. Remember two thanksgivings ago when you developed that eating disorder?

SPIROS

I still have it, and it was **your idea** to start running.

NICO

I was saving you from an early grave.

SPIROS

I have a stringent diet of chicken and broccoli conjoined with body dysmorphia that waxes and wanes.

NICO

You took it too far.

SPIROS

We took it that far.

NICO

But the boys like you so much more now.

SPIROS

HA!

The room goes silent. Spiros looks around as if someone might have heard him. He holds in his outbursts going forward. The Family saunters in.

NICO

It's like we're getting closer to being one and the same. That's how it should be. Not everyone believes there's a better version of themselves traipsing about.

SPIROS

(whispers)

Somedays I wish I had never met you.

NICO

(whispers)

You can't wish away a personality disorder.

SPIROS

What you need is a better personality. You are not what I created or envisioned for myself.

NICO

I hate what you are.

SPIROS

I hate what you are.

The boys cross their arms and turn from one another. A single light on Spiros. He stands and addresses the audience sincerely.

SPIROS

I'm learning to get over myself. I know that I'm nothing more than a commodity to be traded on the market of life. I'm not a necessity— no one needs me. Yet, I'm not some luxury either— I've never been that fine in the eyes of men. I'm a thing. Not worth any sort of weight in silver or gold, no matter what value I give myself. No matter the amount of energy or time I put into this body or passion I pull from my heart. All of it's futile in the end. And I think the next boy will be the one who cares. He'll be the one who will listen, learn, and love me as much as I need to love someone who is just as misunderstood.

NICO

Misunderstood or incapable of understanding? To be misunderstood someone has to desire to understand you.

SPIROS

I don't think that person exists, so I make choices to neglect this reality. I don't always make good choices. The fact I make bad choices drives me wild, but I like these bad choices.

NICO

You make destructive choices.

SPIROS

I make *dangerous* choices and I enjoy them.

NICO

They're choices you've made before and you know they lead to ruin.

SPIROS

But I go on making them because they are the only ones that pan out for me. I know their ending. They're easier to make. It fills a desire. A hole in my heart. On the days when the choices aren't enough, I drink to fill up my heart with liquid courage. And God is it good, even when he isn't. Because sometimes God does forsake me. When it's late and bleak. When all the shadows have gone from my room, I am by myself. Alone in a misery so indescribable that I would never wish it upon anyone. It's a misery so lonely and absent of love that I will never be loved again.

NICO

Tonight we are alone in misery.

SPIROS

Tonight we are alone in misery.

NICO

We are among family.

SPIROS

And at the same time, my heart is with my friends.

The dinner guests enter the space and take their place at the grand table. Spiros and Nico hold up their wine glasses.

SPIROS

These glasses don't have wine in them because we're all staunch prohibitionists in this family.

Spiros snaps his fingers and a young cousin dressed in waiter's whites fills his cup with a pinot noir. He goes to other members of the dinner, Amanda, Tori, Lorelei, and Barry to fill their cups as well.

SPIROS (CONT'D)

But I'm a liar, and good at keeping it a secret. So I drink, and so do they.

The alcoholics raise their glasses to toast.

THE DRINKERS

To hell.

(they look to The Family, hell on Earth)

May the stay there be as pleasant as the way there.
(they drink)

SPIROS
 We're all a little uncouth.
(to the family)
 I have a secret. Would you like to hear it?

THE FAMILY
 NO.

SPIROS
 Alright, I respect that. But can I? Just one.

GRAM
 You're being naive thinking we don't know what it is.

SPIROS
 I'm naive, I'll agree with you about that.

PAPAW
 I don't want to hear about your sins.

SPIROS
 Okay, yes it's a dirty one, but only because of my truth. I'm going to tell you anyway.
(beat)
 I wish I had a baby and I have no idea how to get one. I know I'm too young, but the idea of a child makes me happier than any of you ever could.

LORELEI
 You're no ray of sunshine for us either darlin.

TORI
 Now Lorelei, hold on. I think having a baby would be wonderful.

BARRY
 Spiros, you don't want a fucking kid. You just want a companion. You just need something to come home to at night. I get it. We all do.

SPIROS
 Well, it could be you, but you won't move in with me.

BARRY

Because we would kill each other.

SPIROS

And yet, being alone makes me want to—

BARRY

Do you think with an attitude like that you should be taking care of another human being? You can't support it financially, let alone mentally.

SPIROS

Lorelei. Tori?

LORELEI

He's not moving in with us.

TORI

It could be fun. Like an eternal sleepover.

LORELEI

Exactly. There's already enough mental instability in our household. I'm not adding to it.

SPIROS

Listen to me. The idea of a kid brings me some solace. Some much needed peace. And trust me when I say I need some fucking peace. Maybe it'll heal my mind. It makes me think there's a reason to be here. That's why I wake up every day, because one of these days there'll be someone waiting for me to wake them.

BARRY

I am not letting you expose your "crazy" to a small, impressionable, innocent, human.

SPIROS

Fine. You get your wish. I don't even have a woman to have this baby with.

AMANDA

HA.

(drinks)

Spiros, we all know you're gay.

The Family freezes and looks at Amanda.

SPIROS

Well, no one here knew that.

AMANDA

Well, I thought it was obvious.

GRAM

My Spiros is not gay.

SPIROS

Gram, yes I am.

GRAM

I'm not listening.

BARRY

One day you should just bring a boy to one of these and everyone will believe you. Give them some cold hard evidence. Well, make sure he isn't hard. That wouldn't be kosher at all.

SPIROS

I brought you. Isn't that enough?

BARRY

I'm a friend.

SPIROS

You're a gay.

BARRY

So are you, and don't expose me in front of your family like that.

TORI

It's very rude of you.

LORELEI

Nobody wants to be outed, Spiros. You of all people should know that. You're aunt just did it. Doesn't that make you upset? It should. Don't go around ruining people's lives just because yours is.

TORI

Hunny, don't worry. No one's listening to her.

BARRY

No one in my family ever believes me when I say I'm gay.

TORI

That's tragic.

LORELEI

That's tragic.

SPIROS

I have got to choose someone to have this baby with.

A group of young handsome men takes the stage. Gabriel, Rainer, and Dorian. They're all close to Spiros in age. He looks them up and down, passing judgment on each of them.

RAINER

What do you look like naked?

LORELEI

Well, isn't he charming?

GABRIEL

I'm lanky, loaded, and I love Jesus.

DORIAN

You look amazing and should come over tonight. We can watch Star Wars.

BARRY

Don't be such a puss.

LORELEI

Barry!

BARRY

Sorry.

TORI

Go talk to one of them.

Spiros approaches the lot. He hesitates about who to speak to first.

SPIROS

Hello.

THE MEN

Hi.

SPIROS

Do any of you have plans for Christmas?

GABRIEL

Taos.

RAINER

Ohio.

DORIAN

Utah.

THE MEN

I'm going on a ski trip.

SPIROS

(looks to The Gaggle flustered)

Of course, you are. Do all gay men ski except for me?

LORELEI

It sure as hell sounds like it.

SPIROS

Do lesbians ski?

TORI

No, we don't. We're homebodies.

BARRY

Ask them how big their dick is!

TORI

Barry, you can't ask that.

LORELEI

The polite thing to ask is if they're a top or bottom.

TORI

(slaps Lorelei's arm)

What do you care?

LORELEI

It's not for me. It's for him.

THE GAGGLE

We're trying to help.

SPIROS

Well? The people want to know.

THE MEN

I top.

NICO

Perfect! Are you going to tell them you actually don't like bottoming? How the expectation of intercourse every day as the submissive one/

ALL

Hurts.

BARRY

You know, I bottomed once. But it's okay. I'm a top now, so you can have them. I can teach you if you want to try flipping with them. Though I warn you, it's not as fun as it sounds.

NICO

Spiros, face it. You're gonna get what you deserve, and you could never top. I on the other hand/

TORI

Maybe you should get to know them before you do anything with them. This way you'll know if the sex will be meaningful or boring.

BARRY

Or fulfill a need.

THE MEN

We've all got needs.

LORELEI

The three of you are toxic. I was just asking for essential information. You don't want to fall in love with someone you can't enjoy.

SPIROS

Do any of you think you'll enjoy me?

LORELEI

But I'm not saying you should have sex right away.

GABRIEL

Probably too much.

RAINER

At least once.

DORIAN

Well, I'm a virgin.

THE GAGGLE

Dear God.

BARRY

Who put him in the lineup?

LORELEI

Wait a minute! There is nothing wrong with being a virgin. You guys are so fucking superficial.

SPIROS

I quite like it. If you had my body count you'd like the idea of a virgin too. Something about the lack of lust espouses a sense of loyalty.

DORIAN

Who says I don't lust?

BARRY

You just want someone to teach.

SPIROS

Yeah, I do.

NICO

What about it?

AMANDA

Darling, put it away and come back to dinner.

SPIROS

Mandy.

AMANDA

I'm not an idiot. Your papaw is about to say grace. If I were you I'd pray to get as far away from this place as you could.

SPIROS

You got pretty far.

AMANDA

I'm close enough to make it to these things, so not far enough.

(beat)

And be careful... with them. Protect your heart.

SPIROS

(looks to the boys)

Don't worry about me... Most of these will probably end before they begin.

Rainer and Dorian depart while Gabriel stays rooted in his place.

SPIROS

One unlucky boy will meet me halfway. We'll tell ourselves we love each other.

NICO

The best parts will be fake and the worst parts will be moments of insanity. Being together will swallow you whole.

SPIROS

We're going to rip each other to shreds.

GABRIEL

We're going to rip each other to shreds.

SPIROS

I'll look for every way to put us back together.

Gabriel goes to sit, hesitates, then leaves. The Family bows their heads and takes up each other's hands. The Gaggle takes a stance against the prayer and does not bow their heads, but still holds hands. Spiros joins them back at the table, looks at his friends, and bows his head.

PAPAW

Dear Lord, we pray for the sanctity of life. We pray that you guide us toward the people we need and that you use them to draw us closer to you. We pray for loyalty and light. Tie us to you and those we love. We pray for the things we want and the things we don't know we need. Thank you for the blessings of today and for the blessings of tomorrow.

LORELEI

I'm blessed with a good headspace.

TORI

I'm blessed by my person.
(grabs Lorelei's hand)

BARRY

I'm blessed with loyal friends.
(puts his arm around Spiros)

SPIROS

I'm blessed... with the ability to love and the desire to do so.

PAPAW

In Jesus Christ's name we pray.

ALL

Amen.

Blackout. *The candles dim, then sputter out.*